

India Capital Markets & Insurance

AI vs. Human - India Insurance: AI startups trying to disrupt online distribution - can they succeed?



Manas Agrawal
+91 226 842 1446
manas.agrawal@bernsteinsg.com



Himank Sangai
+91 226 842 1452
himank.sangai@bernsteinsg.com

AI startups have the potential to compete with incumbent financial product distribution businesses (detailed views [here](#)). Insurance needs more hand-holding than other products. PB Fin has a strong brand & an army of tele-advisors that service warm leads from the website, and close sales over a call (selection, documentation, claims). They have a dominant position in the insurance distribution market. We think startups will leverage AI voice-bots/chat-bots to try and break that dominance. At the same time, PB Fin has the opportunity to improve tele-advisor productivity & unit economics.

1. AI startups are coming - can they win? Imagine an AI-powered insurance expert who can 'talk' to customers about their insurance purchase like a human. Take the PB Fin tele-advisor away and replace it with an AI bot (voice/ chat). An AI-native experience where you can talk to an AI advisor and decide what insurance to buy. Zyra AI (private) is building this. We see more challengers rising, planning AI-powered call-centers ([link](#)). They may fail, but they will try, unlike the past.

2. AI vs. Human - unit economics: PB Fin pays ~INR 10.5/minute in salaries for customer talk-time (~INR 50k/month, ~25 days/month, 8 hours/day, ~40% of advisor time spent talking to customers, [Exhibit 3](#)). AI bots can 'speak' with customers at ~INR 4-5/minute, using frontier models (lower with cheaper/open-source models).

Yes, both do not sound the same, and would have very meaningfully different conversion rates. The cost/minute favors AI, but the cost/sale or cost/revenue still tilts towards humans, for now. That may change as AI advances. AI-augmentation should be the base case for tele-advisors/call-center operations, may be even replacement.

3. Competition from voice-agents: AI-augmentation opportunity is very real, even today. Better AI models (more human-sounding, cheaper) could make a case for AI-replacement as well. Today, PB Fin wins because of its brand, and its trained tele-advisory force - a unique right-to-win. Rivals have not tried to build assisted-selling models since it is difficult to manage a large tele-advisory force, and the high cost of driving web traffic for a new entrant. AI voice-bots give challengers some help in navigating the first hurdle. We expect challengers to leverage AI to build new assisted-selling models.

4. Productivity opportunity for PB Fin: While we expect competition, PB Fin also stands to benefit if they execute well on AI automation. PB Fin's tele-advisors spend only ~40% of their time talking to clients (balance time used in managing data/ processes). They expect call-times to jump from ~40% to ~90% of advisor time using AI ([Exhibit 1](#)). If achieved, that would halve the cost/minute for PB Fin, while maintaining their high sales conversion metrics driven by the human-in-the-loop strategy. Even if we assume lower (than claimed) productivity gains, there is a material difference in cost/minute, and a meaningful source of margin expansion for PB Fin. *Continued on the next page...*

DETAILS

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Call-center salary costs are ~40% of the core business top-line for PB Fin today. A lower number can materially improve contribution margins today, and in the steady-state assumptions for investors ([Exhibit 3](#)). This may come as a timely offset as they look to navigate potential take-rate regulations.

5. Applications beyond online insurance distribution: The productivity boost for PB Fin is large due to the nature of the business, but any sales function with client engagement as a key metric can benefit from higher clients/employee, and thus drive better unit economics & margins. We share our detailed views [here](#).

Wealth managers can empower relationship managers (RMs) with AI tools to manage more clients. More clients per RM is more AuM/RM, which in turn is more revenue and profits/RM. This expands the margin profile as well since the cost base does not grow in line with the revenue line in such a case.

Mutual fund distributors (MFDs), and **MF sub-distributors** like Prudent (not covered) can leverage AI to augment their technology platform driving higher client conversions, and better client level reporting and recommendations. **Banks** can enhance branch-level teller/RM productivity. **Insurers** can invest in improving agency channel sales productivity, and so on.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We think AI startups will bring competition to the financial services distribution space. Insurance is the toughest product to sell, and PB Fin has done well to build a large and efficient sales machinery. Erstwhile competitors did not succeed due to the lack of a strong brand and their unwillingness to invest in the tele-advisory setup (call-center sales). We think AI will allow challengers to compete on the assisted selling model where PB Fin has built an edge. At the same time, AI offers PB Fin the opportunity to materially improve its own unit economics, driving higher productivity for the tele-advisory force and thus lower the cost of the call-center operations. This is a timely opportunity as it grapples with a potential compression in take-rates from regulatory action. While the report focuses on online insurance sales, we think the productivity boost opportunity equally applies to agency insurance sales, wealth managers, mutual fund distributors, etc.

We rate PB Fin Outperform.

EXHIBIT 1: PB Fin: AI implementation aims to drive tele-advisor productivity from ~40% to ~90%



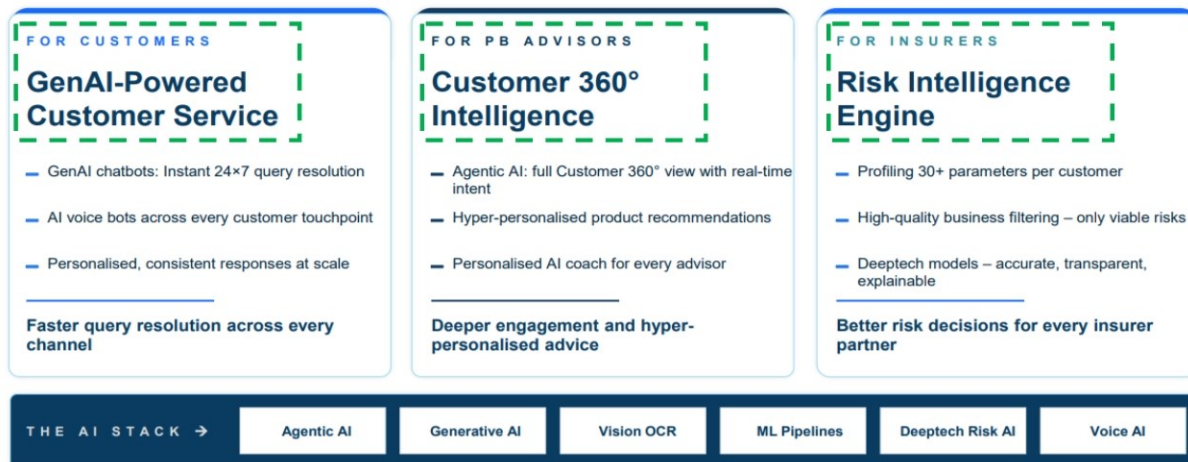
Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 2: **PB Fin's AI strategy - Customer, Advisors, Insurers (Do what was not possible without AI)**

AI EMBEDDED IN HOW POLICYBAZAAR OPERATES, SERVES & SCALES

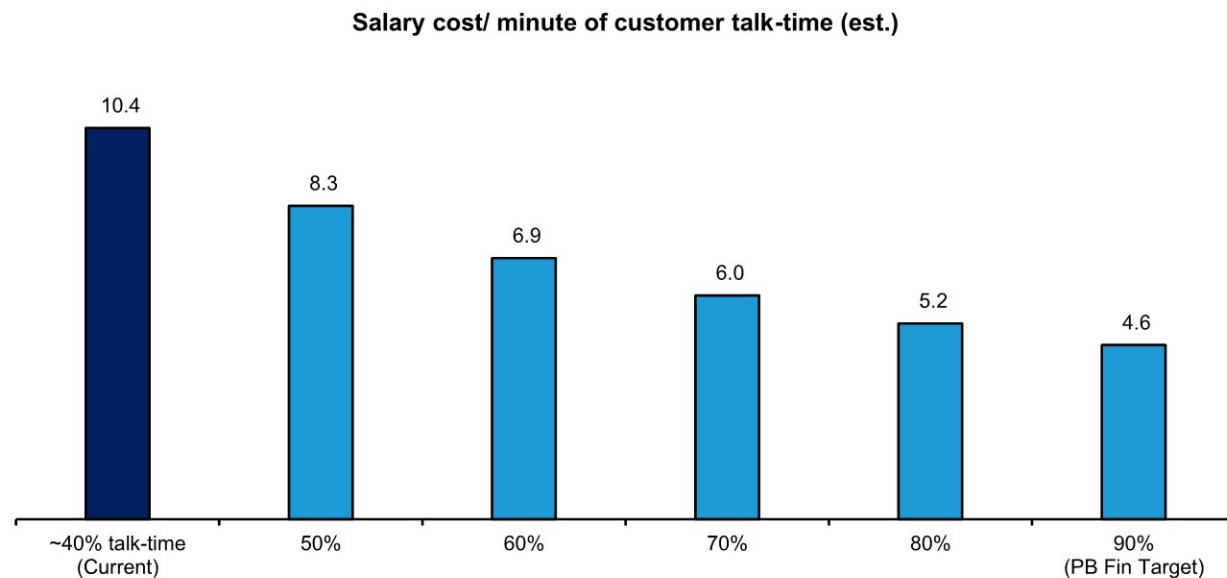


The PB AI Operating System



Emphasis has been added (green highlights)

Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: **Salary costs for PB Fin's call-center operations can be much lower from AI productivity boost (higher customer talk-time per advisor)**

We compute cost/minute of customer talk-time considering monthly salary as INR 50k, 25 working days per month of 8 working hours per day, with a ~40-90% productive customer talk-time across scenarios

Source: Company disclosures, Bernstein estimates and analysis

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Ticker	Rating	Cur	3 Jun 2026		TTM Rel. Perf.	Reported EPS				Reported P/E (x)		
			Closing Price	Price Target		Cur	2026A	2027E	2028E	2026A	2027E	2028E
ANANDRAT.IN (Anand Rathi Wealth)	M	INR	1,785.20	3,280.00	30.2%	INR	36.17	45.21	56.90	49.4	39.5	31.4
360ONE.IN (360 ONE)	O	INR	1,072.50	1,330.00	(46.1)%	INR	29.19	33.99	41.54	36.7	31.6	25.8
HDFCAMC.IN (HDFC Asset Mgmt)	O	INR	2,510.00	2,890.00	(44.9)%	INR	57.38	64.64	70.20	43.7	38.8	35.8
HDFCLIFE.IN (HDFC Life)	O	INR	574.40	810.00	(75.1)%	INR	8.86	9.66	10.63	64.8	59.5	54.0
ICICIAMC.IN (IPRU AMC)	O	INR	3,342.90	3,500.00	NA	INR	53.65	66.33	75.71	62.3	50.4	44.2
IPRU.IN (ICICI Prudential)	M	INR	476.90	680.00	(76.7)%	INR	10.94	10.69	10.74	43.6	44.6	44.4
LICI.IN (LIC)	M	INR	402.90	990.00	(66.3)%	INR	90.84	100.76	115.54	4.4	4.0	3.5
MAXF.IN (Max Fin)	O	INR	1,559.60	2,080.00	(47.2)%	INR	9.53	9.82	8.75	163.7	158.8	178.3
NAM.IN (Nippon Life)	M	INR	1,077.80	880.00	(6.6)%	INR	20.03	22.20	26.39	53.8	48.5	40.8
NUVAMA.IN (Nuvama)	O	INR	1,558.10	1,800.00	(44.4)%	INR	56.06	65.89	77.52	27.8	23.6	20.1
POLICYBZ.IN (PB Fintech)	O	INR	1,578.50	2,310.00	(65.1)%	INR	14.46	26.89	35.49	109.2	58.7	44.5
SBILIFE.IN (SBI Life)	O	INR	1,784.20	2,440.00	(50.3)%	INR	24.62	26.20	27.83	72.5	68.1	64.1
ASIA			2,056.69									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

ANANDRAT.IN, HDFCAMC.IN, ICICIAMC.IN, MAXF.IN, NAM.IN base year is 2025;

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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